3.2 The United States at War

California's state flag features an unusual combination of items: a grizzly bear, a lone red star, and the words "California Republic." The history of this unique flag stems from an event that took place in the 1840s.

MAIN IDEA The United States took control of New Mexico and California after forcing Mexico to surrender at the end of the Mexican-American War.

TERRITORIAL SETTLEMENTS

Despite some Americans' opposition to the Mexican-American War, the United States had the upper hand from the start. On August 18, 1846, General **Stephen Kearny** and his troops marched into Santa Fe, the capital of the New Mexico Territory. They had expected to face strong opposition from Mexican troops and militia, but they found the city unguarded. For unknown reasons, Santa Fe's Mexican governor, Manuel Armijo (ahr-MEE-hoh), had decided not to fight. The United States claimed the New Mexico Territory without a single soldier firing a weapon.

Meanwhile, dramatic events unfolded in California. On June 14, 1846, American settlers took over the town of Sonoma and declared their independence from Mexico. They declared that their land was now the Republic of California. Because of their flag—which featured a grizzly bear—their **insurrection**, or rebellion, would become known as the **Bear Flag Revolt**. American explorer and survey expedition leader **John C. Frémont** headed to Sonoma, where he gave his support to the settlers.

The Republic of California, with Frémont as its elected leader, had a very short life, however. The insurrection had been carried out by a group of settlers who were not connected with, or acting under orders from, the U.S. government. Within days, American forces took control of the area and claimed California for the United States. In August 1846, the U.S. Army also captured the city of Los Angeles, and by November, the conquest was complete.

By 1847, the United States controlled all of California and New Mexico. American military leaders then turned toward Mexico itself. The Mexican Army was busy in the California and New Mexico territories, leaving strategic Mexican cities vulnerable to attack.



State of California Flag
The present-day state flag of California is much like the one used by the California battalion that supported the U.S. Army in taking control of California. It includes the same elements as the Bear Flag of that battalion. The grizzly bear symbolizes strength, the star stands for independence, and the red color represents courage.

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CRITICAL VIEWING In this 1847 color print, artist Christian Mayr depicts one of the more dramatic events of the Mexican-American War: General Scott's entrance into Mexico City. Based on what you see in the print, how does the artist represent people's reception of Scott and his troops?



INVADING MEXICO

Zachary Taylor, the leader of the troops that had crossed the Nueces River to spark the war, had enjoyed some success near the Rio Grande. Taylor now entered Mexico, pursuing retreating Mexican troops. He fought Santa Anna at Buena Vista in 1847. Though the battle seemed to be an even fight, Santa Anna withdrew his troops, and Taylor now controlled northern Mexico.

Because Taylor was reluctant to mount a large-scale invasion of Mexico, Polk changed the American strategy. He ordered General **Winfield Scott** to take his troops to Mexico by sea. Scott and his men landed at Veracruz, which they captured after a three-week siege. They then fought their way toward the capital, Mexico City.

After another fierce battle on the outskirts of the city, American troops entered the capital. In September 1847, Scott gained control of Mexico City and raised the flag of the United States.

Mexico had surrendered and the war was over, but politicians were divided about what to do with the conquered territory. Some wanted the United States to claim all of the territory conquered in the war, while others wanted to claim only the disputed territories. Some politicians argued that the United States should claim no territory at all. Any treaty between the United States and Mexico would have to settle this debate.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was the Bear Flag Revolt?
2. **EXPLAIN** How did the battles over New Mexico and California territories give the U.S. Army an advantage?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** Why did some politicians argue that the United States should not claim any territory in Mexico?

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